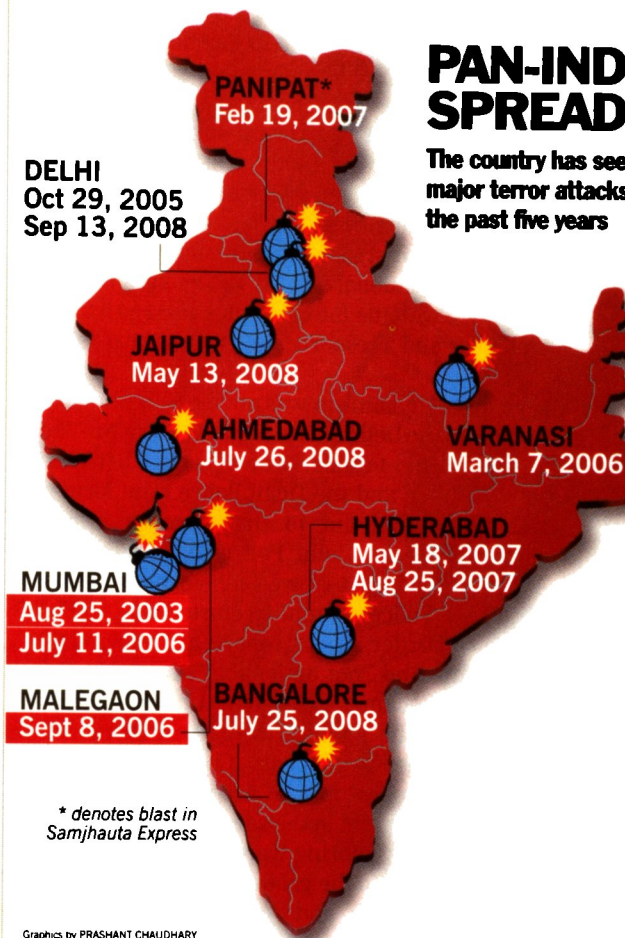


PAN-INDIA SPREAD

The country has seen 12 major terror attacks in the past five years



By targeting MAJOR CITIES, the terror group's strategy is to PUSH urban India into chaos and undermine the economy.

in the late 1980s, have come up in the past 10 years under the SIMI banner. The IM membership is drawn mainly from SIMI, with mostly Indian nationals, but there is no doubt that they are getting funds and support from Pakistan-based jihadi outfits, Dawood Ibrahim and the ISI.

The organisation's agenda and core ideology is formed around their vision about an Indian jihad movement shorn of any outside influence. As Nagori and Bashir told investigators: "We believe that for jihad to take root deep inside India, the main actors had to be Indian Muslims and outside agencies could play a supportive role." Says a senior police official, "The IM has spawned numerous self-motivated terror modules, which have a system of cut-offs from each other but are controlled by central figures."

Propaganda plays a key role in the IM's

twisted world view. There are subtle or overt messages being distributed through various magazines being published in different states and in different languages. One article in *Tehrik* is titled "*Abadi Mein Izafa*" (Spurt in Population) and implores the Muslims to increase their population in order to Islamise the world to save it from "bad influence, anarchy and disintegration." What is startling is that it calls upon Muslims to settle in ghettos at all entry and exit points to cities, towns and villages. In the jihadi video-audio material seized by the Gujarat police from the homes of some of the arrested IM operatives, there are three CDs with footage showing the killings of Muslims by American forces in Afghanistan and Iraq, another with speeches of bin Laden and his deputy Ayman al-Zawahiri. Two others comprise footage of atrocities on Muslims in Bosnia and during the 2002 Gujarat riots. Says political analyst Vidyut Thakar who has studied radical Islamic movements: "Injuries suffered by Muslims in riots like those in Gujarat in 2002 are used as instruments to spread their ideology to attract more youths."

However, most terrorism experts are convinced that Pakistan's involvement is inevitable—a belief repeated by the prime minister in his statement. However, the new strategy is to project the Indian face of terror and give Islamabad and the ISI the cloak of deniability. In any event, the IM's agenda is chillingly clear: create panic, target metros and major cities, create a vicious cycle of hate and violence and thereby, increase the feeling of anger among urban Indians which will increase communal mistrust and push more Muslims into their fold. The other strategy is that by targeting cities like Delhi, it will put pressure on the Government to rush into tougher anti-terror laws, like it seems to have done now, and increase the opportunity for Muslims to be harassed and the law to be misused, like it was under POTA, and increase the sense of alienation. The ultimate aim is to create a communal tinderbox that fuels enough widespread violence to stall India's economic growth and weaken the Indian state. The direct beneficiaries of that are Pakistan and indirectly, China.

Tackling this new threat is a daunting task. "The long-standing obsession of security agencies with Pakistan-sponsored terrorist outfits has led to the oversight of a domestic terror network that grew insidiously across the country in the past three years," says a senior official of the